

GREAT BARRIER REEF

The world's most famous reef system

Possibly Earth's most massive single ecoregion, the Great Barrier Reef—actually 3,000 interlinked reefs—is 1,430 miles (2,300 km) long, more than 62 miles (100 km) wide in parts, and covers 133,200 sq miles (345,000 sq km). More than 400 species of coral polyps (small anemone-like creatures) constructed the reef system among 900 islands. Its waters are warm, sunlit, clear, and bathed by mild currents. Dazzling reef fish, shrimp, starfish, sea slugs, and other sea creatures hide, feed, and claim territories here, while more than 100 species of shark and ray hunt among them. Around 200 species of bird also live here all year round.

Complex ecosystems

Along the reef, temperatures climb several degrees from south to north, and the seabed profile continually changes. Mingling with the reefs themselves are inshore waters averaging 115 ft (35 m) deep, sandy cays, seagrass meadows, sponge gardens, and mangrove stands, all giving way to continental slopes plunging down 6,560 ft (2,000 m). As one of the planet's most complex and biodiverse ecoregions, the Great Barrier Reef is carefully managed and conserved in some respects, but industrial and agricultural pollution, while declining, are still large-scale problems. In addition, rising water temperature and acidity linked to climate change, which causes environmental upheaval, are intensifying threats.

The Great Barrier Reef receives more than **2 million tourists** every year



CROWN-OF-THORNS STARFISH

SPINY ENEMY
Crown-of-thorns starfish periodically plague the reef. By eating polyps, they have destroyed up to one-quarter of its coral cover. Land nutrient run-off aids their increase in numbers, because it increases plankton, which in turn feeds larval starfish.

BLACK NODDY

BIRD BREEDING HUB

The Great Barrier Reef supports over one-quarter of Australia's tropical breeding birds, and more than half the population of one species, the black noddy. Noddy nests are made of leaves, twigs, and debris cemented with their own droppings.

BRAIN CORAL

CORAL DIVERSITY

The reef's builders are 450-plus species of stony or hard corals. Their polyps construct limestone cups and calcareous skeletons around their soft bodies. Coral colonies grow into patterns that resemble antlers and even brains.

The Great Barrier Reef is the largest living structure on the planet
Declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1981